of products at the service of its female consumer—be it scented and self-warming lubricants, dotted condoms available readily on e-commerce sites, personal pleasure massagers or a whole array of sex toys.

Most people, however, remain averse to using them. The survey results show that both men and women are aware of products that improve female pleasure but less than half would be willing to actually use such products even if it meant more pleasure for themselves. The pleasure gap seeps in here as well. More men seem open to using sex toys to increase their pleasure than women—38.5 per cent men versus 36 per cent women. Traditional mindsets play a spoiler too. More male respondents (42 per cent) were judgemental of women using sex toys than their female counterparts (37 per cent). "I would be afraid to use a sex toy not just out of fear of what others would think of me but also what I would think of myself," says Neha Kumar (*name changed*), 24, a Delhi-based student. Sex itself is nothing negative or shameful for her, but masturbation or using a sex toy? She wouldn't even entertain the thought. Contrary to her belief, her fiancé does not think there would be anything wrong if she did use sex toys. "I don't think I am ready yet to focus only on my own pleasure. Changing that mindset will need time. Right now, it feels too self-indulgent. I was brought up to believe focusing on yourself is not the right thing to do," she says.

BOTH MEN AND WOMEN ARE AWARE OF SEX AIDS, BUT LESS THAN HALF ARE WILLING TO USE THEM

People like Neha may still be hesitating to embrace their sexuality, but a whole lot of Indians are also working towards building a sex-positive mindset, for themselves and others. A number of sex influencers online are encouraging both men and women to be more sexually vocal, aware and accepting. Millennial doctor Tanaya, for example, runs an Instagram page called Dr Cuterus, where she tries to break popular misconceptions about sex and reproductive health. 'Sexuality educator' Karishma posts a variety of information on topics ranging from condoms to lubricants, from sexual shame to sexual expectation on Talk You Never Got. Simran Balar Jain, another sex educator, tackles uncomfortable sexual subjects in an attempt to normalise them and to promote safe sex practices. "Sex is a part of life, and sexual health contributes to your overall well-being. Such a thought process needs to be normalised across gender, ages and geographies," says Dr Kothari.

The pleasure gap opens up when needs and expectations are not met. Ignorance, stressful lifestyles, self-imposed and social stereotypes are a few of the reasons why Indians are not getting what they need from sex. Normalising sex, instead of treating it as an exceptional act, is an important first step towards greater awareness, more reasons to make time for it (just like one would for the gym), have more conversations and debates around it, and more openness to explore different solutions. What we need less of is stigma. ■

METHODOLOGY

The INDIA TODAY Sex Survey was conducted by Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA) between December 2022 and January 2023 in 19 cities across all zones of the country among 3,032 adults who were sexually active.

The respondents have been selected randomly to prevent any bias from creeping into the samples. We have followed a multi-stage sampling process: at the first stage, any major factors that could cause sampling errors have been controlled through an appropriate selection process (among males, females, geographical distribution, sexuality, age, etc.). In the second stage, contact points with the respondents are a mix of colleges/ universities, shopping malls/ multiplexes, hostels/ lodges, restaurants, etc. This is an adaptation of the queuing theory, where randomisation is built into the system. The confidence level is 95 per cent with an error of margin of ± 1.78 per cent.

A structured questionnaire was administered to the respondents by experienced and trained investigators of the MDRA through quantitative face-to-face interviews. It must be noted that in view of the sensitivity of the subject and questions, the survey was conducted through self-administered questionnaires, that is, the respondents have filled up the questionnaires themselves.

